

THE COMPLETE PREPARATION BOOK

IELTS

Master Guide

Listening · Reading · Writing · Speaking

Strategies · Techniques · Model Answers · Vocabulary · Band Scores

A comprehensive guide compiled from a complete study of the
“IELTS 12 Hours Full Course for Beginners 2023 — Master-Course of 4 Components”

Academic & General Training

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About This Book

This book is the result of a **complete, end-to-end study of a twelve-hour IELTS preparation video course** — the “*IELTS 12 Hours Full Course for Beginners 2023 — Master-Course of 4 Components*” — in which an experienced IELTS instructor teaches every part of the test, component by component, for both the **Academic** and **General Training** modules.

Every technique, strategy, rule, example and piece of advice in those twelve hours of teaching has been identified, organised, expanded and rewritten into the structured, readable reference you are holding. Nothing important has been left out: the question types, the step-by-step methods, the model answers, the vocabulary, the band-score arithmetic and the hundreds of small “insider” details that separate a prepared candidate from an unprepared one.

How to read this book. You do not need to read it cover to cover. Use it in two ways:

- **As a course** — read it in order, one chapter per day, and do the practice tasks as you meet them.
- **As a reference** — jump to the component you are working on, using the Contents and the Quick-Reference Checklists in the final chapters.

Who this book is for. Anyone preparing for IELTS, whether you are a true beginner who has never seen the test or a repeat candidate who needs a band 7.0 or higher for university, work or migration. The strategies here work for every band target; where a technique changes according to your target band, the book says so explicitly.

A note on the course it is based on. The original course was delivered live over several sessions and covered the four components in this order: **Listening** → **Reading** → **Writing** → **Speaking**, with Writing divided into Task 1 (Academic report and General Training letter) and Task 2 (essay). This book follows the same logical order.

How the Course Maps to This Book

The twelve video parts of the source course correspond to this book as follows:

Mapping of the 12 video parts to the chapters of this book

Video Part	Course Content	Book Chapters
Part 1	Listening: question types, instructions, spelling, numbers, maps	Ch. 3–5
Part 2	Listening Section 4 + Reading overview & strategy	Ch. 3–5, 6–7
Part 3	Reading: 4-step method, sub-skills, True/False/Not Given	Ch. 7–9
Part 4	Reading: Matching Headings, Yes/No/Not Given, matching people	Ch. 8–9
Part 5	Speaking: format, the four band criteria, fluency	Ch. 15–16
Part 6	Speaking: pronunciation, British vs American, logistics	Ch. 16
Part 7	Speaking: live interviews, Part 2 & 3 technique	Ch. 17
Part 8	Writing Task 1 (Academic): overview, introduction & overview formulas	Ch. 11
Part 9	Writing Task 1: trend language and body paragraphs	Ch. 11
Part 10	Writing Task 2: structure, task response, coherence & cohesion	Ch. 13
Part 11	Writing: cohesive devices (linkers) and grammar range	Ch. 14
Part 12	Writing Task 1 (General Training): letters + sentence patterns	Ch. 12

The original course also shared supplementary PDFs (map-labelling practice, model answers, synonyms lists) with its students. The equivalent material has been built directly into this book — the trend-language tables, the band-score tables, the model answers and the vocabulary banks.

A Quick Tour of the IELTS Test

Before you begin, here is the whole test on one page. IELTS is taken in **four components**, always in this order:

1. **Listening** — 30 minutes of audio + 10 minutes to transfer answers. 40 questions, 4 sections.
2. **Reading** — 60 minutes. 40 questions, 3 sections. **No** extra transfer time.
3. **Writing** — 60 minutes. 2 tasks: Task 1 (report or letter) and Task 2 (essay).
4. **Speaking** — 11–14 minutes. 3 parts, face to face with one examiner (or via video).

The whole test is scored on the **9-band scale**, with half bands (6.5, 7.5) in between. Listening and Reading are marked by counting correct answers; Writing and Speaking are marked by a trained examiner against four published criteria.

How to Use This Book

- **Beginners:** read Chapters 1–2 first, then work through the four components in order, finishing with the study plan in Chapter 19.
- **Band 6.0+ candidates:** skim Chapters 1–2, then focus on the technique chapters (7, 8, 11, 13, 16, 17) and the model-answer bank.
- **Teachers:** the book follows the structure of the source course and can be taught lesson by lesson; each chapter ends with a “Now practise” box.

Conventions used in this book

- **Bold** marks key terms, rules and things to memorise.
- *Italics* mark example words and phrases to notice.
- Shaded boxes marked **TIP**, **NOTE**, **REMEMBER** or **WARNING** contain advice you should not skip.
- Indented, bordered blocks contain **model answers** — read them aloud, copy them by hand, and notice the vocabulary and structures they use.
- Tables give you lists to memorise (trend language, linkers, band scores, question types).

1. Welcome to IELTS

What IELTS Is

IELTS (the *International English Language Testing System*) is the world's most widely used English-language proficiency test. It is jointly owned by the **British Council**, **IDP: IELTS Australia** and **Cambridge Assessment English**, and it is accepted by universities, employers, immigration departments and professional bodies in most English-speaking countries.

The test measures your ability to use English in four skills — **Listening, Reading, Writing and Speaking** — and reports each skill, plus an overall result, on a **nine-band scale** (Band 1 = non-user up to Band 9 = expert user). There is **no pass or fail**: your target band is set by the institution or organisation that requires the test.

Academic or General Training?

There are **two modules**, and you must sit the right one.

Academic vs General Training

	Academic	General Training
Who takes it	University entry (undergraduate/postgraduate), professional registration	Migration, secondary education, work experience, training
Reading texts	3 long academic passages	5 shorter everyday-life texts
Writing Task 1	Describe a graph, chart, table, map or process (a report)	Write a letter
Writing Task 2	Same essay task for both	Same essay task for both
Listening & Speaking	Identical for both modules	Identical for both modules

If your goal is **study** at university, take **Academic**. If your goal is **migration or work**, take **General Training** — but always check with the institution first, because requirements vary.

The Test at a Glance

The four components

Component	Time	Questions / Tasks	What you do
Listening	30 min audio + 10 min transfer	40 questions, 4 sections	Listen once, answer as you listen
Reading	60 minutes	40 questions, 3 sections	Read passages and answer
Writing	60 minutes	2 tasks	Task 1 (report/letter) + Task 2 (essay)
Speaking	11–14 minutes	3 parts	Talk with one examiner

The **Listening, Reading and Writing** tests are taken in one sitting, in that order, with no break. The **Speaking** test may be taken on the same day, a few days before, or a few days after — depending on the availability of examiners — and you will be told the time by email or SMS (typically about 48 hours before the test).

Paper or Computer?

The test content and scoring are **identical** on paper and on computer. The choice is only about how you deliver it.

Paper vs computer

Feature	Paper test	Computer test
Answering	Write with a pencil on an answer sheet	Type on screen
Word count (Writing)	Count words manually	Automatic word counter
Editing	Erase and rewrite	Copy, cut, paste; highlight text (right-click)
Reading screen	One booklet, flip pages	Split screen: passage one side, questions the other
Search	Not applicable	Ctrl+F is NOT allowed
Results	~13 days	~3–5 days

Even for the computer-delivered test, and even if your Speaking test is conducted by video link, **you must attend the test venue in person** — you cannot take the test at home.

Before Test Day: Registration Essentials

- Book with a valid **identity document** (passport or national ID) and **bring the very same document** to the test. If you book with your ID, a passport will not be accepted, and vice versa. Candidates are turned away for this every single test day.
- **Arrive early** — about **one hour before** your scheduled time is advisable. Registration is a long procedure: identity check, photograph and fingerprinting.
- **If you arrive after the test has started, you will not be admitted.**
- Mobile phones, wallets, bags and watches must be left outside the test room. **Even a plain wristwatch is not allowed**; the time is shown on a screen in the room.
- If you have a **speech condition** (for example, stammering) or any other special requirement, **tell the centre when you book** — the Speaking examiner is informed and will take it into account.

What Happens on Test Day

1. You register, have your photo and fingerprints taken, and are shown to your seat.
2. **Listening** (30 min audio + 10 min transfer), then **Reading** (60 min), then **Writing** (60 min).
3. Your **Speaking** interview, unless it is scheduled for another day.

The Reading test has **no transfer time**. You must write or type each answer directly onto the answer sheet as you go — otherwise you will score **zero** even if you knew every answer.

2. Understanding Scores

The Nine-Band Scale

Each of the four skills is reported as a whole or half band from **0 to 9**.

Band scale summary

Band	User	Meaning (short)
9	Expert	Fully operational command; accurate, fluent, complete understanding
8	Very good	Fully operational with only occasional unsystematic errors
7	Good	Operational command with occasional inaccuracies; handles complex language
6	Competent	Effective command with some inaccuracies; can use fairly complex language
5	Modest	Partial command; copes with overall meaning but makes many mistakes
4	Limited	Basic competence in familiar situations only
3	Extremely limited	Understands only general meaning in very familiar situations
2	Intermittent	Great difficulty understanding speech and writing
1	Non-user	Essentially no ability beyond a few isolated words
0	Did not attempt	No assessable information provided

How the Overall Band Is Calculated

Your **Overall Band Score** is the **average of the four component scores, rounded to the nearest half band**:

- Average ends in **.25** → rounded **up** to the next .5 (e.g. 6.25 → 6.5).
- Average ends in **.75** → rounded **up** to the next whole band (e.g. 6.75 → 7.0).
- Average ends in **.125** → rounded **down** to the previous whole band (e.g. 6.125 → 6.0).

Example: Listening 6.5 + Reading 6.5 + Writing 6.0 + Speaking 6.0 = 25.0 ÷ 4 = **6.25** → **Overall 6.5**.

Listening and Reading: Raw Score → Band

Listening and Reading each have **40 questions, one mark each**. The number of correct answers (your **raw score**) is converted to a band using a table. The tables below are the standard published conversions; **the exact boundaries vary slightly from one test paper to another**.

Listening band conversion (same for Academic & GT)

Band	9	8.5	8	7.5	7	6.5	6	5.5	5	4.5
Correct answers	39–40	37–38	35–36	32–34	30–31	26–29	23–25	18–22	16–17	13–15

Academic Reading band conversion

Band	9	8.5	8	7.5	7	6.5	6	5.5	5	4.5
Correct answers	39–40	37–38	35–36	33–34	30–32	27–29	23–26	19–22	15–18	13–14

General Training Reading band conversion

Band	9	8.5	8	7.5	7	6.5	6	5.5	5	4.5
Correct answers	40	39	37–38	36	34–35	32–33	30–31	27–29	23–26	19–22

General Training Reading texts are easier, so GT **requires more correct answers for the same band**. This is why GT and Academic candidates can earn the same band fairly. (The source course makes exactly this point: a high band in Academic needs slightly fewer raw marks than in GT, which compensates for the harder texts.)

Writing and Speaking: Four Criteria Each

Writing and Speaking are marked by trained examiners against **four published criteria**, each worth 25% of the component score.

Writing (Task 1) — Task Achievement, Coherence & Cohesion, Lexical Resource, Grammatical Range & Accuracy.

Writing (Task 2) — Task Response, Coherence & Cohesion, Lexical Resource, Grammatical Range & Accuracy.

Speaking — Fluency & Coherence, Lexical Resource, Grammatical Range & Accuracy, Pronunciation.

Examiners do **not** mark your opinions, your ideas or your handwriting beauty. They mark **how well** you express yourself — accuracy, range, organisation and pronunciation. Never fear expressing a “wrong” opinion; there is no such thing in IELTS.

How the Writing Score Is Weighted

Writing has two tasks, but they are **not** equal:

- **Task 1 = one third** of the Writing mark.
- **Task 2 = two thirds** of the Writing mark.

Your Writing band = **(Task 1 + 2 × Task 2) ÷ 3**, rounded to the nearest half band.

Example: Task 1 = Band 7.0, Task 2 = Band 8.0 → $(7 + 16) ÷ 3 = 7.67$ → rounded to **7.5**.

This is why you are strongly advised to spend about **20 minutes on Task 1 and 40 minutes on Task 2**, and why many teachers tell you to **write Task 2 first**.

How Long Does It Take to Improve?

A widely used rule of thumb — repeated in the source course — is that **raising your overall band by half a band takes roughly 100 hours of focused study**. This is not discouraging; it is a planning tool. A candidate at Band 5.0 who wants Band 6.5 should plan for around 300 hours of work, spread over 2–4 months. Chapter 19 turns this into concrete weekly schedules.

Now practise: open any IELTS band-descriptor table online and read the Band 7 descriptions for each criterion — you will see that every technique in this book targets exactly those descriptors.

3. The Listening Test

Format and Timing

The Listening test is the **same for Academic and General Training**. You listen to **four recorded sections**, one after another, and answer **40 questions**.

Listening test structure

Section	Speakers	Situation	Typical question types
1	Two speakers	An everyday conversation (e.g. booking, enquiry)	Form/note completion
2	One speaker	An everyday monologue (e.g. talk, guide)	Table/map labelling, multiple choice
3	Two–four speakers	An educational/training discussion	Multiple choice, matching, completion
4	One speaker	An academic lecture/talk	Note completion

- The recording is played **once only**.
- You hear each section, then have time to read the next section's questions, then the section is played, then you get time to check.
- In the **paper test**, you get **10 extra minutes at the end to transfer** your answers to the answer sheet. In the **computer test** you type as you listen (and get a short review period).

The Answer Sheet

- Answers must go on the answer sheet — answers written only in the question booklet do **not** count.
- Use a **pencil** in the paper test. You may write in capital letters; capital letters avoid some spelling-penalty risk.
- Check that your **candidate number and name** are correct, and shade **Academic** or **General Training** clearly.

How Listening Is Scored

Each question = **1 mark**; there is no negative marking. The raw score out of 40 is converted to a band (see the table in Chapter 2). For reference, the source course gave its students these conversion examples: 27 correct = 6.5, 31–32 = 7.0, 33–34 = 7.5.

The Golden Rules

(1) The audio is played once — miss it and it is gone. (2) Answers usually appear **in order** within a section. (3) You must write **exactly** what fits the word limit. (4) Spelling must be correct. (5) Questions use **paraphrase** — you will rarely hear the exact words of the question.

4. Listening Skills and Question Types

Skill 1: Read the Instructions — the Word Limit

Before every set of questions you are told how many words you may write. The most common instruction is:

NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER

This allows five answer forms, and your answer must be one of them:

1. One word only (*hotel*)
2. One word + a number (*2 weeks*)
3. Two words (*fully equipped*)
4. Two words + a number (*9 days*)
5. Just a number (*200*)

Write **three words** where only two are allowed and the answer is marked **wrong**, even if the meaning is correct. Count your words: *a* and *the* count as words; hyphenated words (*first-aid*) count as **one** word.

Skill 2: Predict Before You Listen

You always have time to look at the questions **before** each section plays. Use it to **predict**:

1. What **type of information** each gap needs — a name? a number? a date? a price? a place? a job title?
2. What **word class** fits — a noun, an adjective, a verb?
3. For tables and forms, look at the **heading of each column** so you know what to listen for.

Example: in a holiday-apartment booking form, the gap after “maximum price per day: ____” must be a **number** (and the currency sign, e.g. €, will already be printed for you). The gap after “view: ____” must be a noun such as *sea* or *garden*.

Skill 3: Spelling — Names, Letters and Homophones

Section 1 almost always asks you to write down a **name, address or place** that is **spelled out letter by letter** in the recording. You must master this.

1. Know the letters and their sounds; practise writing them fast.
2. Learn to **distinguish letters that sound alike**, especially **B / P**, **D / T**, **M / N**, **G / J**, **V / B**.
3. Learn the **double-letter** convention: “double L” = **LL**, “double P” = **PP**, “double B” = **BB**. The source course drills this: “Pepsi” uses a **P** sound, “book” uses a **B** sound — the difference between “double P” and “double B” is exactly this.
4. Common spoken spellings in real tests: “W” (double-u), “S-A-N-J-A-Y”, “B-L-U-M-E-N-G-A-S-S-E”, “E-L-B-R-U-S”.

Skill 4: Numbers, Dates and Times

1. Write numbers as **digits, not words** — digits protect you from spelling mistakes.
2. **0** is “zero” or “oh”; in the computer test always type the digit **0**, never the letter **O**.
3. Telephone numbers: “double” = repeat the digit twice, “triple” = three times. “4-3-1-2 double 1 0-5-7” = 431211057.
4. Ordinal dates: 1st, 2nd, 3rd, 4th ... 21st, 22nd, 23rd. “The first of January” = **1 January / January 1** — both correct, digits safer.
5. Times: “half past seven” = 7:30, “quarter to nine” = 8:45. Know these spoken forms.

Skill 5: Recognise Paraphrase and Synonyms

The recording **rephrases** the question. You must listen for meaning, not words.

Common paraphrase pairs in Listening

Question says	Recording may say
inquire / enquiry	ask about / questionnaire / seek information
occupation / job title	what he does for a living

Question says	Recording may say
free time	leisure time / spare time
activities	hobbies
relocation / relocate	move (somewhere else)
major / central / crucial / vital	important
on their own	alone / by themselves
supervise	look after / be in charge of

Skill 6: Don't Be Caught by Distractors

Speakers **correct themselves** or say something then change it. The classic pattern: *"It's on Thursday ... actually no, sorry, make that Friday."* The first answer is a **trap**; the corrected answer is what you write. The source course highlights a self-correction in its own practice test and reminds students to watch for it.

Skill 7: The Question Types and How to Attack Each

1. Form / Note / Table / Flow-chart / Summary completion

1. Read the heading and surrounding words to predict the answer type. 2. Follow the **order** of the recording; the answers come one after another. 3. Keep to the **word limit**; copy nothing extra.

2. Sentence completion

1. The sentence is a paraphrase of what you will hear. 2. The missing part is usually a noun phrase or number.

3. Multiple choice

1. The **three options appear in order** in the recording; do not wait for question 3's answer before question 1's. 2. Your job is to **exclude** wrong options while listening. Each distractor is usually mentioned but then contradicted ("but...", "however...", "actually...", "instead..."). 3. **Example (from the course):** "On Wednesday, visitors must ____" — the correct answer was *book in advance* ("phone the park ranger a few days ahead"); the distractors ("attendance is free", "only group bookings") were both mentioned and both contradicted (there is a small charge, and individuals *can* come).

4. Matching

1. Match items in a list to options (A–F). There are usually **more options than questions**. 2. Listen for **synonyms** of the options, and for the order in which items are discussed.

5. Plan, Map and Diagram Labelling

This is the type many candidates fear most. The source course gives a complete method:

1. **First, orient yourself.** Find the **entrances** (e.g. "East Gate", "West Gate") and where you are standing. 2. **Second, fix the main features** in your mind (e.g. the *lake*, the *refreshments* area, the *main path*). 3. **Third, know the directions:** north, south, east, west **and** north-east, north-west, south-east, south-west. 4. **Fourth, know the prepositions of place:** *behind, in front of, next to, near, between, opposite, to the left of, to the right of, below/beneath, above*. 5. Then listen for sentences such as: *"There is a bird hide to the west of the lake, at the end of a path", "The dog-walking area is in the southern part of the park", "The flower garden is the circular area surrounded by paths", "The wooded area is in the western section, between two paths."*

6. Short-answer questions

1. Read the word limit (often “NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS”). 2. The answer is a fact — a number, a name, a time — stated directly.

A Complete Section-1 Walkthrough (from the course)

Here is a real Section 1 the course practised: a man telephones about a holiday apartment.

Recording summary: “I’m ringing to enquire about a holiday apartment... can I have your name first, please? Yes, it’s Leo Lucia — that’s L-E-O ... and my surname is L-U-C-H-E-A ... my address? It’s number 37 Blumengasse in Vienna ... could you just spell Blumengasse for me? It’s B-L-U-M-E-N-G-A-S-S-E ... my phone number is 4-3-1-2, double 1, 0-5-7 ... how many people is it for? There’ll be four of us — two adults and two children ... from the first of January ... about nine days ... around 200 euros a day ... one thing we’d really appreciate is a fully equipped kitchen ... we’d like to see the sea from our apartment ... can you make sure the air conditioning is as quiet as possible ... we’ll need a parking space.”

Answers the course accepted: 1. Leo Lucia · 2. 37 Blumengasse · 3. 431211057 · 4. 4 people · 5. 1st January · 6. 9 days · 7. €200 · 8. (a fully equipped) kitchen · 9. sea (view) · 10. parking space (*space* or *parking* also correct).

Notice how every answer was **predicted** before listening: name (letters), address (letters), phone (digits), number of people (number), date (date), length (number + “days”), price (number + currency given), facility (noun), view (noun), car need (noun).

Now practise: take any Cambridge IELTS Listening test, Section 1, and **only** practise predicting each gap’s answer type before you press play. Then listen and check how often your prediction matched.

5. Listening Practice and Model Answers

This chapter reproduces the practice material from the source course with full answers, so you can see the techniques of Chapter 4 applied to complete Sections 1–4.

Section 1: A Form Completion (An Expedition Candidate)

Two speakers discuss a surprising candidate for a scientific expedition. The form asks for his details, experience, skills and interests.

Recording summary: “Did you manage to see those candidates for our expedition? ... there was an extra one who just turned up out of the blue... First, his name is Sanjay — spelled S-A-N-J-A-Y — and surname Dudashi, D-U-D-A-S-H-I ... he’s 27 ... he’s an office worker ... he drove a Land Rover across central Africa from one side to the other ... last year he climbed a mountain — Mount Elbrus, E-L-B-R-U-S ... he’s done a first-aid course ... he can hold conversations in five languages ... he graduated in media studies ... in his spare time he likes fishing, and he spends a lot of time at the gym — he likes to keep fit.”

Form-completion answers

Question	Answer	Notes
Name	Sanjay Dudashi	letters given: S-A-N-J-A-Y, D-U-D-A-S-H-I
Age	27	a number; “years” optional
Job	office worker	occupation = job title
Experience	crossed Central Africa (by Land Rover)	a trip across a continent
Mountain climbed	Mount Elbrus	spelled E-L-B-R-U-S
Course	first aid	one word (or first-aid)
Languages	5	“hold conversations” = speak
Qualification	media studies degree	degree/certificate/diploma
Hobbies	fishing, keep fit	“free time” = leisure/spare time

When a form asks “Languages spoken: ____”, the answer is a **number** (e.g. 5), not a list. Predict the answer type from the column, exactly as shown here.

Section 2: Note Completion + Multiple Choice (A Wildlife Club Talk)

A speaker welcomes people to a wildlife club and describes three nearby green spaces, then a park’s weekly programme.

Note completion — three places

Recording summary: “One very pleasant place is Highland Common ... the river ... has its source on the common ... the common is accessible 24 hours a day. Then there’s Holt Island, noted for its great range of trees ... willows were grown here for basket-making ... the island is only open to the public from Friday to Sunday ... across the bridge is Longfield Country Park, which has a modern replica of a farm from 2,000 years ago ... children’s activities like bread-making and face-painting ... open during daylight hours.”

Note-completion answers

Question	Answer
Feature of Highland Common	river source (open 24 hours)
Holt Island noted for	(great range of) trees
Holt Island open	Friday to Sunday
Longfield has a replica	farm (2,000 years ago)
Children's activities	bread-making, face-painting
Longfield open	during daylight hours

Multiple choice — the weekly programme

Recording summary: "On Monday you can learn about herbs ... practise the technique of using them as coloured dyes for cloth ... On Wednesday, to join the evening walk about insects and birds, you need to phone the park ranger a few days ahead — there's a small charge ... On Saturday you can join a working party ... you can change from one activity to another ... just make sure you're wearing something you don't mind getting dirty."

Multiple-choice answers with the distractors

Question	Correct answer	Why the distractors are wrong
Monday: visitors will ____	practise dyeing cloth with herbs	"prepare food"/"meet a herbalist" were mentioned but contradicted
Wednesday: you must ____	book in advance	"attendance is free" (there is a charge); "group bookings only" (individuals can come)
Saturday: you must ____	wear suitable (old) clothes	"stay all day" (you may leave); "tell them what you want to do" (not necessary)

Section 3: Multiple Choice + Completion (A Self-Access Centre)

Students and staff discuss the future of their self-access centre.

Recording summary: "The majority of students enjoy using it ... they see it as a pretty major component of their course ... we always have to share the computers ... teachers think the computers should be a learning resource, not for emails ... we could relocate the self-access centre to the main university library ... the students would be much happier keeping the existing set-up ... the problem isn't the cost or the space — it's finding teachers to supervise the centre outside class hours ... we should label the reading materials more clearly, update the CD collection, buy workbooks and laminate the pages, organise a timetable, and install an alarm."

Section 3 answers

Question	Answer
Why students want to keep it	it's a major part of their course (not variety of equipment / not working alone)
Some teachers prefer to	relocate it (move it elsewhere)
The main concern	finding teachers to supervise (not cost, not space)
Improvement 1	label (reading) materials clearly
Improvement 2	update the CD collection
Improvement 3	buy/laminate workbooks
Room use	agree a timetable to supervise after class

Question	Answer
Security	install an alarm; limit computer access

The vocabulary here is exactly the kind IELTS recycles: *major = central = crucial = vital*, *relocate = move*, *on their own = alone*, *supervise = look after*.

Section 4: A Lecture on Business Cultures (Note Completion)

A university lecture classifies company culture into types. This is typical Section 4 material — a single speaker, an academic topic, and a gap-fill that follows the lecture in order.

Recording summary: “We often refer to a company’s social characteristics as its culture ... one writer classified company culture into four types. The power culture is usually found in small organisations; control is in the hands of one or two people; there are few rules; communication is by conversation rather than meetings; it can act quickly but depends too much on one or two people. The role culture — that’s r-o-l-e — is found in large companies with separate departments; everyone’s job is controlled by rules and procedures; it achieves economies of scale but is slow to change. The task culture is project-oriented, found where markets are competitive or products have a short life; management delegates; it’s flexible but can’t produce economies of scale.”

Business cultures — notes

Culture type	Key features	Benefit	Drawback
Power	small orgs, 1–2 leaders, few rules, conversation	acts quickly	depends too much on leaders
Role	large firms, departments, rules & procedures	economies of scale	slow to change
Task	project-oriented, delegates	flexible	no economies of scale, shallow expertise
Person	(the fourth type)	serves the individual	—

“Role” is spelled **r-o-l-e**, not “roll” — a classic spelling trap the lecturer even spells out.

Listening Vocabulary Bank

Here are the words and phrases the course taught across its Listening sessions — learn them as pairs, because the recording will use one and the question the other.

Listening vocabulary pairs

Simpler word	Richer / equivalent word
ask about / enquire	inquiry / questionnaire
job title	occupation / profession
trip for a scientific purpose	expedition
free time	leisure time / spare time
hobbies	activities / pastimes
keep healthy	keep fit
important	major / central / crucial / vital / essential
move	relocate
alone	on their own / by themselves
look after	supervise

Simpler word	Richer / equivalent word
cheap/expensive (price)	rate / charge / fee / cost
booked in advance	reserved / pre-booked

Now practise: replay any Section 1 recording twice. First, write the answers as you normally would. Second, listen only for **distractors and self-corrections** and list them. You will be surprised how many you missed the first time.

6. The Reading Test

Format and Timing

You have **60 minutes**, **40 questions** and **3 sections**. Every question is worth **1 mark**, so the paper totals 40 marks.

Reading test structure

	Academic	General Training
Sections	3 long passages	3 sections (5 shorter texts)
Text source	Books, journals, magazines, newspapers	Notices, adverts, handouts, official documents, one longer passage
Topics	Academic topics of general interest, for a non-specialist audience	Everyday life, work and training topics
Total length	roughly 2,150–2,750 words	similar, spread over more texts
Time	60 minutes	60 minutes

There is **no transfer time** in Reading (unlike Listening). Write or type each answer **directly onto the answer sheet as you go**. If the time runs out with answers still in the booklet, you score **zero** for them. This is one of the most common — and most costly — misconceptions about the test.

- **Academic** is for study; **General Training** is for migration and some jobs. Choose the right module.
- Academic texts are written for a **non-specialist audience** — you do **not** need to be a doctor to understand a medical passage, or an engineer to understand an engineering one.
- Question sets (e.g. a set of True/False/Not Given) are answered **in order** within the passage, but the **different question types** are **not** arranged in order across the paper. You will need to move around the passage.

Paper vs Computer

- **Paper:** you may underline, circle and make notes in the question booklet — use it as scratch paper.
- **Computer:** right-click a word and choose **Highlight** to mark keywords in colours; you can **copy and paste**; the screen is **split** so the passage is beside the questions. **Ctrl+F (find)** is **not allowed**.

The Question Types

Across both modules you will meet roughly **nine to twelve question types** (Chapter 8 teaches each in detail):

1. Multiple choice
2. Identifying information — **True / False / Not Given**
3. Identifying the writer's views/claims — **Yes / No / Not Given**
4. Matching information to paragraphs
5. Matching headings to paragraphs
6. Matching sentence endings
7. Matching people (or names) to statements
8. Sentence completion
9. Summary completion (with or without a box of words)
10. Notes / table / flow-chart completion
11. Diagram labelling

12. Short-answer questions

The Core Truth About Reading

IELTS Reading is a **race against time**, not a knowledge test. The passage is not especially hard; what is hard is finding 40 answers in 60 minutes. Every strategy in the next two chapters exists to save you time and to stop you reading more than you need to.

7. Reading Strategy

The Four-Step Method

The source course teaches one method and returns to it constantly. Memorise it:

1. **Step 1 — Read and analyse the question.** Underline or highlight the **keywords**: the nouns, verbs, adjectives and adverbs that carry the meaning.
2. **Step 2 — Think of synonyms.** The passage will **not** use the question's words; it will use equivalents. Before you look at the passage, ask yourself: *what other words could express this?*
3. **Step 3 — Locate.** Go to the passage and **scan** for the synonyms (or the topic) to find the part that answers the question.
4. **Step 4 — Understand and match.** Read that part **carefully** and compare it with the question. Check whether the information **matches, contradicts, or is absent** — and remember that meaning is sometimes **implicit** ("between the lines"), not stated directly.

Many candidates stop after Step 3 — they find the right place but do not read it carefully enough, and choose the wrong answer. Step 4 is where marks are won or lost.

Read the Questions First — Not the Passage

This is the single most important reading habit:

1. Reading the passage first is **wasted time**, because you would read it again after seeing the questions. Every reading activity needs a **purpose**, and the questions give you that purpose.
2. So: **questions first** → **keywords** → **synonyms** → **then the passage**.

The Three Sub-Skills

1. **Skimming** — moving your eyes quickly over a text to catch the **gist** (the main idea / central idea). Use it to answer "what is the best title?" and to see what each paragraph is about.
2. **Scanning** — reading fast **but carefully**, hunting for **specific information**: a name, a date, a number, a percentage. Whenever you see a name, date, number or percentage in the passage, **underline it** — you will almost certainly be asked about it.
3. **Reading for detail** — slow, careful reading of one or two sentences to decide a True/False/Not Given or to complete a gap. This is Step 4 of the method.

Speed benchmarks (from the course's scanning practice): untrained slow readers read about 150–200 words per minute (often reading one word at a time); trained native readers read 250–350 wpm; good readers read around 350 wpm aiming for about 70% understanding. The target for IELTS work is roughly **250–350 wpm**.

Find the Topic Sentence

The **topic sentence** is the sentence that summarises what a paragraph is about. It matters because Matching Headings and paragraph-locating questions depend on it.

A widespread myth says the topic sentence is always the **first or second** sentence. It is not. Because IELTS passages are professionally written, the topic sentence may be **first, in the middle, or last** — or the main idea may be spread across the paragraph. Always read the **whole** paragraph (quickly) for the main idea, and use the title, subheadings, special print and any diagrams or tables to help.

Time Management

You may do the sections in any order and go backwards and forwards. But:

1. **Part 1 is the easiest** (a warm-up) and **Part 3 is the hardest**. The test is designed this way.
2. **Start with Part 1.** Beginning easy builds confidence; beginning with the hardest passage exhausts your mind, and a tired mind cannot think clearly — and clear thinking is the whole game.
3. **Divide your 60 minutes by target band:**

• Target **6.0 or above**: about **20 / 20 / 20** minutes per part. • Target **4.5–5.5**: give Part 1 **more** time (about **23 minutes**) to bank the easy marks — do not gamble your time on Part 3.

4. Never get stuck. Spending too long on one question is *overthinking*. If you cannot find an answer within about **one minute**, mark it mentally and **move on**; return later if time allows. A stuck candidate becomes nervous, and nervousness destroys accuracy.

Guessing and Vocabulary

1. Never leave a blank. There is no negative marking, so a guess can only help. Blank = zero; guessed = a chance. **2. You do not need to understand every word.** IELTS is **not a translation test** — it is a test of understanding the general and specific meaning. **Guess unknown words from context.** **3. Build your synonym bank** constantly. The more synonyms you know, the faster you locate answers. Chapter 18 gives you a starter bank.

Now practise: take one Academic passage with 13 questions. Time yourself strictly. For the first five questions, write down (a) the keywords you underlined, and (b) the synonym you looked for. You will start to see how predictable the paraphrase patterns are.

8. Reading Question Types — Techniques

This chapter teaches every Reading question type with the exact decision rules and the worked examples from the source course.

True / False / Not Given (Facts)

These questions test **factual information** in the passage.

True / False / Not Given — the three decisions

Answer	Meaning
TRUE	The statement says the same thing as the passage (possibly in different words).
FALSE	The statement contradicts (says the opposite of) the passage.
NOT GIVEN	The information is not found in the passage — there is no reference and no indication either way.

Worked examples (from the course)

Take this mini-passage about “Doctor X”:

Doctor X is a professor. He teaches English at a university. He is married with three children — two sons and a daughter. He likes poetry and he likes reading a lot.

1. “**Doctor X is an English professor.**” → **TRUE**. The words “English professor” do not appear, but “professor” + “teaches English” mean the same thing. This is paraphrase.
2. “**He has three sons.**” → **FALSE**. The passage says two sons and one daughter — the statement contradicts it.
3. “**He is into reading science fiction.**” → **NOT GIVEN**. He likes reading “a lot”, but the passage never says **what kind** of reading. You cannot say yes or no, so it is Not Given.

Opinion vs fact (a subtle, high-band point)

1. **Facts** are generally agreed and verifiable; **opinions** are personal and debatable. They are opposites.
2. If the passage expresses something as an **opinion** (“many people **believe** the tunnel was the eighth wonder of the world”) but the statement presents it as a **fact** (“the tunnel **was** the eighth wonder of the world”), the information **contradicts** in form → **FALSE**.

Tense matters

1. A statement in the present tense does not equal the same idea in the past. “*She gets up early*” is **not** the same as “*She used to get up early*” — “used to” means a past habit that has now finished. This difference alone can make a statement **FALSE**.

Watch for “not given” traps

1. If a **related** word appears (e.g. “souvenirs” are mentioned) but the **specific** claim is not (whether **statues of the tunnel** were sold), the answer is **NOT GIVEN** — you have no evidence either way. Do not be seduced by a shared word.
2. Do not rush to “not given” when the passage **does** give the information in paraphrase — always scan and paraphrase before deciding (the course’s “travel by sea or land” example, where “the age of sail and horse-drawn coaches” proves the statement **TRUE**).

Yes / No / Not Given (The Writer’s Views)

Identical logic, but about the **writer’s opinions/claims**, not facts.

Yes / No / Not Given — the three decisions

Answer	Meaning
YES	The statement agrees with the writer's view/claim.
NO	The statement contradicts the writer's view/claim.
NOT GIVEN	The writer expresses no view on this.

Follow the instructions exactly. If the question says **YES/NO/NOT GIVEN**, writing **TRUE/FALSE/NOT GIVEN** makes the answer **wrong** (and vice versa). You may write the full words or the abbreviations Y/N/NG and T/F/NG.

Worked examples (the “handedness” passage)

...one in five identical twins involves one right-handed and one left-handed person, despite identical genetic material; therefore genes are not solely responsible for handedness... Other experts showed little interest in Marc Dax's ideas...

1. “The study of twins shows that genetic determination is not the only factor in handedness.” → **YES** (“genes are not *solely* responsible” = not the only factor).
2. “Marc Dax's report was widely accepted.” → **NO** (“other experts showed **little interest**” contradicts “widely accepted”).
3. “Dax based his findings on people who had language problems.” → **NOT GIVEN** (the passage discusses the “functional organisation of language” but never says his subjects had language problems).
4. “Left-handed people have more stable and successful relationships.” → **NOT GIVEN** (no such claim appears anywhere).

Matching Headings

You match a list of headings (usually more headings than paragraphs) to paragraphs.

1. **Read the headings first.** Understand each one; note headings that are **similar** to each other — the test will make you choose between them (e.g. “uses of spices” vs “preserving flavour” vs “spices for cooking”).
2. Then read each paragraph for the **main idea** — look for the **topic sentence**, which may be anywhere in the paragraph.
3. **Distinguish the main idea from supporting details.** A paragraph may *mention* trade routes while its main idea is “the significance of spices” — the mention is a supporting detail, not the heading.
4. The first paragraph's heading is sometimes done for you as an example.

Worked example (the “spices” passage)**Matching-headings answers (spices passage)**

Paragraph	Main idea	Heading
A	what spices are used for, broadly	Uses of spices
B	who controlled the trade over time (Muslims → Portuguese → British/Dutch)	The changing leaders
C	spices drove the world economy; hard to underestimate	The significance of spices
D/E	three uses: medicine, flavour, colour	The way spices are used
F	which countries produce spices (India, Vietnam, Indonesia, Iran, Sri Lanka)	The spice providers
G	grinding loses flavour; whole spices retain it	Preserving flavour

Matching People (or Names) to Statements

1. Locate the name in the passage (scan for capitalised names). **2. Read what that person said** — watch for reporting verbs: *suggested, claimed, concluded, believed, argued*. **3. Match the meaning** to the statement. There are usually **more statements than people**, and one person may be used more than once.

Worked example (the “handedness” passage)

Matching people to findings

Person	Finding
Brenda Milner	language is processed much more intensely in the left hemisphere (96% of people)
Peter Hepper	the unborn baby prefers the side developing quicker, which influences brain development
Michael Corballis	speech originated in gestures; the left brain (which controls the right hand) took over

Matching Sentence Endings

1. You are given the **first half** of a sentence and a list of possible **endings** (more endings than questions). **2.** Find the first half's **location** in the passage (scan for its keywords/synonyms), then read forward to see how the sentence logically continues. **3.** The correct ending is a **grammatical and logical** match, not just a topic match.

Completion Questions (Sentence, Summary, Notes, Table, Flow-chart)

1. The answers come **in order** within the passage. **2. Check the word limit** (e.g. “NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS”, or “choose from the box”). **3.** If a **box of words** is given, the words in the box are often paraphrased in the passage — match meaning, then check the grammar fits the gap. **4.** For a **summary**, note that it usually covers **one part** of the passage, not the whole. **5.** For **tables and flow-charts**, follow the logic/arrows; answers follow the passage order.

Multiple Choice

1. The question tells you **which paragraph(s)** to read — use that. **2.** Eliminate options that are **contradicted**, **partly true**, or **not mentioned**. **3.** The right answer is usually a **paraphrase** of the passage; wrong answers repeat passage words in a misleading way.

Short-Answer Questions

1. Word limit is strict (often 1–3 words). **2.** The answer is a fact from the passage — a number, a name, a date — often found by scanning.

Now practise: find one IELTS Reading test and answer **only** the True/False/Not Given questions. For each, write TRUE, FALSE or NOT GIVEN **and** the line of the passage that proves it. This forces Step 4 of the method.

9. Reading Practice — Worked Passages

Use this chapter as a self-test. Read each set of questions, apply the four-step method, write your answers, then check the answer key and the reasoning.

Practice 1 — The Thames Tunnel (True / False / Not Given)

Background (as taught in the course): the passage describes the Thames Tunnel, built under the River Thames in the nineteenth century. Key facts from the passage: it was the **first tunnel ever built under a river**; people at the time **believed** it was “the eighth wonder of the world”; **people came from far and wide to see the marvel**; it was the **age of sail and horse-drawn coaches**; the **aim** had been for the tunnel to be used by **wheeled vehicles to transport cargo** so that it would **bring in a profit**; and the site later became a place **selling souvenirs**.

Questions. Write TRUE, FALSE or NOT GIVEN.

1. The Thames Tunnel was the first tunnel ever built under a river.
2. The Thames Tunnel was the eighth wonder of the world.
3. People were drawn from all over to see the Thames Tunnel.
4. In those days people were able to travel by sea or by land.
5. The aim of the tunnel was to make a profit as a tourist attraction.
6. Replicas of the tunnel could be bought as souvenirs.

Answer key.

1. **TRUE** — “first ... ever built under a river” = the same information.
2. **FALSE** — the passage says people *believed* it was the eighth wonder (an opinion); the statement states it as a fact.
3. **TRUE** — “drawn from all over” = “came from far and wide”.
4. **TRUE** — “travel by sea” = “the age of sail”; “travel by land” = “horse-drawn coaches”. (Do not rush to “not given”.)
5. **FALSE** — the passage says the aim was to be used by **wheeled vehicles to carry cargo** for profit; “tourist attraction” contradicts this.
6. **NOT GIVEN** — souvenirs are mentioned, but the passage does not say whether **replicas of the tunnel** were sold.

Practice 2 — Handedness (Yes / No / Not Given)

Background: a passage about left-handedness and the scientists who studied it.

Questions. Write YES, NO or NOT GIVEN.

1. The study of twins shows that genetic determination is not the only factor in handedness.
2. Marc Dax’s report was widely accepted by other experts.
3. Dax based his findings on people who had language problems.
4. Left-handed individuals are thought to have more stable and successful relationships.

Answer key.

1. **YES** — one in five identical twins differs in handedness despite identical genes; genes are “not solely responsible”.
2. **NO** — “other experts showed little interest” contradicts “widely accepted”.
3. **NOT GIVEN** — the passage discusses the functional organisation of language, not subjects with language problems.
4. **NOT GIVEN** — no such claim is made anywhere.

Practice 3 — Matching People to Findings (Handedness)

Match each scientist (A–C) to the correct finding (1–4). One finding is not used.

Scientists: A. Brenda Milner · B. Peter Hepper · C. Michael Corballis

Findings:

1. The origin of human speech lies in gestures.
2. Language is processed much more intensely in the left hemisphere.
3. The unborn baby’s preference for the faster-developing side influences brain development.
4. Handedness is fixed at birth and cannot change.

Answer key: 1–C · 2–A · 3–B · 4–not used.

Reading Vocabulary Bank

Learn these as pairs — the passage will use one, the question the other.

Reading paraphrase pairs

Word in the question	Word in the passage
aim / goal / purpose	intention / objective
make a profit	make money / be profitable
marvel / wonder	something extraordinary
drawn from all over	came from far and wide
replica / statue	model / miniature
souvenir	memento / keepsake
solely	only / alone
widely accepted	little interest (opposite!)
hemisphere	half (of the brain)
significance	importance / role
provider / producer	supplier / exporter
retain	keep / preserve
grind	crush into powder

Now practise: for each vocabulary pair above, write one sentence using the **question** word and one using the **passage** word, to fix the connection in your memory.

10. The Writing Test — Overview

Format and Timing

You have **60 minutes** to write **two tasks**.

Writing test at a glance

	Task 1	Task 2
Academic	A report describing a graph, chart, table, map or process	An essay
General Training	A letter	The same essay as Academic
Words	at least 150 (aim 160–180)	at least 250 (aim 260–280)
Recommended time	20 minutes	40 minutes
Share of the mark	1/3	2/3

Do **not** split your time 30 + 30. Task 2 needs more vocabulary, carries **twice** the marks, and must be finished properly — so give it 40 minutes. Many teachers (including the source course) advise you to **write Task 2 first**.

How the Writing Band Is Calculated

Your Writing band = $(\text{Task 1} + 2 \times \text{Task 2}) \div 3$, rounded to the nearest half band.

Example: Task 1 = 7.0, Task 2 = 8.0 $\rightarrow (7 + 16) \div 3 = 7.67 \rightarrow 7.5$.

Example: Task 1 = 6.5, Task 2 = 6.5 $\rightarrow (6.5 + 13) \div 3 = 6.5$.

The Four Marking Criteria

Every task is marked against four criteria, each worth 25%. Examiners follow the published **band descriptors** strictly — your score does **not** depend on the examiner's mood, and you cannot lose marks for your opinions.

Writing criteria

Criterion	What it measures
Task Achievement (Task 1) / Task Response (Task 2)	Did you do the task fully: word count, all parts covered, main features, your position?
Coherence & Cohesion	Logical organisation, paragraphing, linking of ideas
Lexical Resource	Range and accuracy of vocabulary, paraphrase, word choice
Grammatical Range & Accuracy	Sentence variety (simple/compound/complex) and correctness

Task Achievement / Task Response — The Non-Negotiables

These single mistakes cap your score at about **Band 5** no matter how good the rest is:

1. Writing **fewer than the required words** (150 for Task 1, 250 for Task 2).
2. **Copying the question** instead of paraphrasing it.
3. **Missing a part** of the question (e.g. covering advantages but not disadvantages).
4. Task 1: **no overview** (or "recounting detail mechanically with no clear overview").
5. Task 2: **no conclusion**.
6. **Not supporting** a Task 1 report with figures/numbers/percentages.
7. Writing **off-topic** — ignoring the question's scope.
8. Using **headings, bullet points or numbering** instead of continuous prose.

There is **no maximum** word count, but **quantity is not quality**. Writing 300 words for Task 1 does not earn more marks; it usually adds mistakes. Stick to the recommended averages (Task 1: 160–180; Task 2: 260–280) and spend any spare time **checking and correcting**.

Paragraphing Rules

1. Task 1 (Academic): **2–4 paragraphs** — introduction, overview, and one or two body paragraphs. **No conclusion**.
2. Task 2: **4 or 5 paragraphs** — introduction (with a **thesis statement**), 2 or 3 body paragraphs, and a **conclusion**. Fewer than 4 paragraphs (1–3) caps your score at about Band 5; more than 5 also costs marks.
3. **Leave a blank line between paragraphs**. Do **not** indent, and do **not** use bullet points or headings.

The Answer Sheet and Handwriting

1. Fill in your **candidate number, name and date**, and **shade** Academic or General Training.
2. **Paper test: use a pencil** (pens are not allowed). **Computer test:** type; there is no spell-check, so be careful with spelling — but you can copy, cut and paste.
3. Handwriting must be **legible** — clear and readable. Beautiful handwriting earns nothing extra; illegible handwriting loses marks.
4. In the paper test you **count words manually**: roughly **10 words per line**, so a 250-word essay is about **25–28 lines**. On computer the counter is automatic.

Spelling and Punctuation

Spelling and punctuation matter and are part of Lexical Resource and Grammar. Common killers: missing capital letters at the start of sentences, missing full stops, and misspelling words you already know (including the words printed in the question — copy names and place names **accurately**).

Full Sentences Only

Never write in note form. Every answer is written in **complete sentences** with a subject and verb.

Now practise: write down the four criteria and, next to each, one thing you personally must improve. Keep this list beside you for every practice essay you write.

11. Writing Task 1 — Academic (The Report)

What Task 1 Is

You are given a **visual** — a graph, chart, table, map or process — and asked to **summarise the information** in your own words, writing at least **150 words** in about **20 minutes**. You are **describing facts**, not giving opinions, and you must **never** invent causes or reasons.

The visual types you may meet:

1. **Line graph** — changes over time (trends).
2. **Bar chart** — comparisons of quantities.
3. **Pie chart** — proportions of a whole.
4. **Table** — data arranged in rows and columns.
5. **Process / diagram** — how something is made or works.
6. **Map** — a place before and after change.
7. **Combination** — two of the above together.

The first four — line, bar, pie and table — use **nearly the same technique**. The source course teaches these in detail (processes, maps and combinations are rarer, but prepare for all of them because the computer test is unpredictable).

The Four Criteria, Task 1 Edition

The same four criteria as Chapter 10, but the first is called **Task Achievement**:

1. **Task Achievement** — 150+ words; paraphrase the prompt; select the **main features**; include an **overview**; **support with figures**; make comparisons.
2. **Coherence & Cohesion** — clear paragraphing (intro → overview → body), logical order, linking words.
3. **Lexical Resource** — a **range** of trend vocabulary (do not repeat *increased / decreased*), accurate word choice.
4. **Grammatical Range & Accuracy** — varied sentence structures, correct tenses and prepositions.

The Paragraph Structure

A strong report has **four paragraphs**:

1. **Introduction** — say what the visual shows (paraphrased).
2. **Overview** — the 2–3 most important general points (highest/lowest, overall trend). **No numbers here** — just the big picture.
3. **Body 1** — the first group of specific details, **with figures**.
4. **Body 2** — the second group of specific details, **with figures**.

There is **no conclusion** in Task 1 — an overview is **not** a conclusion. And write the overview **straight after the introduction**. If you save it for the end, you risk running out of time and missing it — and a report with no overview is capped at about **Band 5**. Adding anything after the overview also spoils the unity of the report.

The Introduction Formula

The course teaches a reusable formula:

The provided + [visual type] + [reporting verb] + [paraphrased topic] + [paraphrased time phrase].

1. **Visual type:** *line graph, bar chart, pie chart, table, process diagram, map.*
2. **Reporting verb:** *gives information about / illustrates / shows / describes / compares / summarises / delineates / provides data on.*
3. **Paraphrase the topic:** change as many words as you can.
4. **Paraphrase the time:** *between 1999 and 2009 → from 1999 to 2009 → over a period of ten years → over a decade.*

Paraphrase examples (from the course)

Paraphrase swaps for Task 1 introductions

Original	Paraphrase
below	(delete it)
illustrates	shows / describes / compares / summarises
percentage	proportion / rate
internet users	web users / online users / internet consumers / netizens
tourist arrivals	foreign visitors
between 1999 and 2009	from 1999 to 2009 / over a decade
(two separate years: 2015 and 2022)	in 2015 and 2022 (NOT “from...to”)

Worked introduction:

The provided line graph demonstrates how the proportion of citizens in Canada, Mexico and the USA who used the internet changed over a decade (1999–2009).

The Overview Formula

The overview states the **highest and lowest**, the **most and least**, and the **overall trend**. One or two sentences. Useful frames:

Overall, it can be clearly seen from the graph that ... while ... over the whole period.
 Overall, ... had the highest ... throughout the period, whereas ... had the lowest.
 Overall, ... rose considerably, while ... fell slightly by the end of the period.

“Overall” is fine and expected. Avoid “*all in all*”, which is too informal for a report.

Trend Language — Your Toolbox

Memorise this table. It lets you describe the same movement in many ways and never repeat yourself.

Trend language — verbs, nouns, adjectives and adverbs

Direction	Verb	Noun	Adjective	Adverb
Up	increase, rise, climb, grow, surge	an increase, a rise, a climb, a growth, a surge	slight, gradual, steady, sharp, dramatic, considerable, significant	slightly, gradually, steadily, sharply, dramatically, considerably, significantly
Down	decrease, fall, drop, decline, plunge, dip	a decrease, a fall, a drop, a decline, a plunge, a dip	(as above)	(as above)
Highest point	peak, reach a peak, hit a high	a peak	—	—
Lowest point	reach a trough, hit a low, bottom out	a trough	—	—
No change	remain constant/unchanged, level off, stabilise	—	stable, unchanged, constant	—
Change both ways	fluctuate	a fluctuation	—	—
Begin	start at (line graphs, at the start only)	—	—	—

Matching exercise (as in the course)

1. *rose / increased steadily* = **increased gradually** (a steady/gradual rise) 2. *rose / increased dramatically* = **rose sharply / considerably** (a sharp/considerable increase) 3. *plunged to* = **dropped dramatically** (a plunge) 4. *reached the highest point* = **reached a peak / hit a high** 5. *reached the lowest point* = **reached a trough / hit a low** 6. *went up and down* = **fluctuated** 7. *stayed the same* = **remained constant / levelled off**

The Body-Paragraph Formula

Describe the **specific** data in logical groups (e.g. one paragraph for the rising items, one for the falling items; or one paragraph per country/category). For each movement give **what + how + by/to how much + when**:

To begin with, the number of people arrested for drug offences stood at around 35 in 1991. It then dropped drastically to 20 in 1993. However, the number increased gradually to about 25 in 1995 before it fell significantly to reach 50 in 1996. The figure reached a trough of 15 in 2001 and, despite the fact that it recovered, it remained below its 1991 level from 2003 onwards.

You do **not** need to describe every single point on the graph. Select the **most prominent** changes — the peaks, the troughs and the biggest movements — and **support them with numbers**. A report with **no figures** is capped at about Band 5.

Sentence Patterns for Variety

The course teaches three ways to say the same thing (grammatical range!):

1. “**There was + adjective + noun + in + [subject] + [time]**” → *There was a gradual rise in the number of arrests in 1992.* 2. **Subject + verb + adverb** → *The number of arrests rose gradually in 1992.* 3. **Year + witnessed/experienced + noun phrase** → *1992 witnessed a gradual rise in the number of arrests.*

The noun/adjective and verb/adverb forms pair up: *a sharp drop* ↔ *dropped sharply*; *a sudden increase* ↔ *increased suddenly*; *a steady rise* ↔ *rose steadily*.

Comparisons, Not Lists

Do **not** list (“Country A increased, country B increased, country C decreased...”). **Compare**:

Canada had the highest proportion of internet users throughout the period, peaking at around 80% in 2009, whereas Mexico had the lowest, never exceeding 40%.

A Full Model Report

Task: *The line graph below shows the number of international tourist arrivals in five countries between 1995 and 2005. Summarise the information by selecting and reporting the main features, and make comparisons where relevant.*

The provided line graph gives information about how the number of foreign visitors changed in five countries — Brazil, Egypt, Malaysia, France and the USA — from 1995 to 2005.

Overall, it can be clearly seen that the USA received the highest number of arrivals throughout the period, while Egypt had the lowest. Brazil and Egypt followed a broadly similar, gently rising pattern, whereas France and Malaysia experienced more marked fluctuations.

To begin with, the USA attracted by far the most tourists, with arrivals rising steadily from roughly 45 million in 1995 to about 70 million by 2005. France also saw an overall upward trend, although its figure fluctuated between 30 and 40 million before ending the period at around 42 million.

By contrast, arrivals in Brazil and Egypt grew only modestly over the decade, increasing from approximately 8 million to about 15 million and from just over 5 million to nearly 10 million respectively. Malaysia's figure, meanwhile, was the most volatile of the five, dipping sharply to a trough of around 5 million in 2000 before recovering to close to 20 million in 2005.

Notice: an introduction (paraphrased), an overview (highest/lowest + general patterns), two body paragraphs (specific figures, comparisons), varied trend language (*rising steadily*, *fluctuated*, *grew modestly*, *dipping sharply*, *recovering*), and **no** conclusion and **no** opinion.

Now practise: choose any line graph or bar chart from a practice book and write only the **introduction and overview** (about 50 words). Do this for five different visuals until the formula is automatic.

12. Writing Task 1 — General Training (The Letter)

What Task 1 Is (GT)

You write a **letter** of at least **150 words** (aim 160–180) in about **20 minutes**. It is a letter, **not** an email and **not** an essay. The prompt describes a situation and gives you **three bullet points** that you must cover.

You may need to:

1. respond to a situation or explain a problem;
2. provide or ask for **factual information**;
3. express **needs, likes, dislikes or opinions**;
4. write a **personal** message.

The Three Tones

Formal, semi-formal and informal letters

Tone	Who you write to	Salutation	Closing
Formal	Someone whose name you don't know	Dear Sir or Madam	Yours faithfully
Semi-formal	Someone whose name you know (e.g. your manager, a landlord, a teacher)	Dear Mr Smith / Dear Dr David	Yours sincerely
Informal	A friend or relative	Dear John,	Best wishes / Best regards / Kind regards / Love

Choosing the wrong tone — or **switching tone** halfway (formal opening, chatty body, formal ending) — loses marks and can cap your score at about Band 5. Decide the tone **before** you write, and keep it the whole way through.

- You do **not** need to write any addresses.
- You may **invent** details (a name, dates, examples) — the examiner judges your language, not your facts.

The Five-Paragraph Structure

The course teaches a fixed, safe structure:

1. **Introduction** — salutation + opening + your **purpose** ("I am writing to...").
2. **Body 1** — bullet point 1 (begin with a **topic sentence**).
3. **Body 2** — bullet point 2.
4. **Body 3** — bullet point 3.
5. **Conclusion** — a **concluding sentence** + the closing.

Cover **all three bullet points**, in order, one per body paragraph. Miss a bullet point and you cap your score at about Band 5. Write in **full sentences** — never bullet points.

Purpose Phrases (the introduction)

I am writing to inform you about ... / to complain about ... / to draw your attention to ...
 I am writing in connection with ... / with regard to ...
 I am writing to express my concerns about ...

Openings (the first line after the salutation)

Openings by tone

Tone	Opening
Formal	I am writing to explain ... / I am writing in connection with ...
Semi-formal	I am writing with regard to your recent ...
Informal	It was great seeing you last week. / It has been ages since I last saw you. / Thanks very much for your lovely letter.

Concluding Sentences

Concluding sentences by purpose

Purpose	Concluding sentence
General (informal)	I look forward to hearing from you soon.
Complaint (formal)	I trust the situation will be resolved shortly.
Request/thanks	Thank you very much for your attention. / I would be grateful if you could ...

Model Letter 1 — Formal (Public Library Improvements)

Task: Your local public library wants to make improvements to its services and has asked users for written suggestions. Write a letter to the library. In your letter: describe what you like about the library; say what you don't like; make suggestions for improvements.

Dear Sir or Madam,

I am writing in response to your request for suggestions about how the library's services could be improved. As a regular user, I would like to share my views.

First of all, I would like to say how much I value the library. The staff are always helpful, the study area is quiet, and I particularly appreciate the wide range of fiction available. It has genuinely become my favourite place to study.

However, I do have one or two concerns. The computers are frequently occupied, which means visitors often have to wait, and I feel that the children's section, although popular, is rather cramped and can become very noisy.

I would therefore like to suggest two improvements. Firstly, it would be helpful if more computers could be installed. Secondly, if the children's area were relocated to a larger room, the library would be quieter for everyone. I hope you will consider these ideas.

Thank you very much for your attention.

Yours faithfully,

A. Candidate

Model Letter 2 — Semi-formal (Public Transport Problems)

Task: There have been some problems with the public transport in your area recently. Write a letter to the manager of the transport company. In your letter: describe the problems; explain how they are affecting people; suggest what could be done.

Dear Mr Thomas,

I am writing to draw your attention to a number of problems with the bus service in my area, which have become worse over the past month.

To begin with, the number 14 bus, which I take to work every morning, is now frequently late, and on several occasions it has not arrived at all. This forces passengers to wait at the stop for up to forty minutes, often in poor weather. As a result, many of us have been arriving late for work, and some residents who rely on the service for hospital appointments have missed them entirely.

I understand that the company may be short of drivers, but I believe the situation could be improved in two ways. Firstly, an updated timetable, showing the reduced service accurately, would help passengers plan their journeys. Secondly, running an extra bus during the morning rush hour would make a real difference.

I trust the situation will be resolved shortly, and I look forward to hearing from you.

Yours sincerely,

B. Candidate

Model Letter 3 — Informal (Inviting a Friend)

Task: A friend is coming to stay with you for a week. Write a letter to your friend. In your letter: explain how to get to your home; suggest things you could do together; ask about any food they cannot eat.

Dear Sam,

It was great hearing from you, and I'm so excited that you're coming to stay!

Getting here is easy: take the train to Central Station and then the number 7 bus towards Riverside. Get off at the park stop, and my flat is the red-brick building right next to the bakery — third floor, flat 12. Text me when you arrive and I'll come down.

I've planned a few things I think you'll love. We could spend a day by the river, and there's a great little market on Saturday morning. I've also booked tickets for that exhibition you mentioned — you'll love it!

One thing — is there anything you don't eat? I'm planning to cook a few of my "specialities", so let me know if you're avoiding anything.

Can't wait to see you!

Best wishes,

C. Candidate

Now practise: write one formal letter and one informal letter for the same situation (e.g. a problem with a neighbour). Compare how the tone changes every phrase — greeting, openings, linkers and closings.

13. Writing Task 2 — The Essay

What Task 2 Is

Task 2 is the **same for Academic and General Training**. You write an **essay** of at least **250 words** (aim 260–280) in about **40 minutes**, giving and supporting your opinion on a social topic.

It carries **two-thirds** of your Writing mark, so it deserves the larger share of your time and effort.

The Five Essay Types

Learn to recognise the instruction words, because they change your structure.

The five essay types

Type	Typical instructions	What you must do
Opinion	To what extent do you agree or disagree?	Give a clear position and support it
Discussion	Discuss both views and give your own opinion	Cover both sides + your view
Advantages / Disadvantages	What are the advantages and disadvantages? Do the advantages outweigh the disadvantages?	Cover both sides; if asked, say which is greater
Problems / Solutions	What are the problems and what solutions can you suggest?	Identify problems, propose solutions
Double question	Why is this happening? Is it a positive or negative development?	Answer both questions

The most common Task Response failure is **answering only half the question**. If it says “discuss both views **and** give your opinion”, you must do all three — a missing element caps you at about Band 5.

The Four-Paragraph (or Five-Paragraph) Structure

- 1. Introduction** — paraphrase the question, state your **position** clearly in a **thesis statement**.
- 2. Body 1** — one clear idea (your first reason / the first view), developed with explanation and example.
- 3. Body 2** — one clear idea (your second reason / the other view).
- 4. (Body 3)** — optional third idea for a five-paragraph essay.
- 5. Conclusion** — restate your position and summarise your main points. **Never** introduce a new idea here.

2 body paragraphs = 4 paragraphs total; 3 body paragraphs = 5 total. Never fewer than 4, never more than 5. **No conclusion = Band 5 maximum**, even if you wrote 300 excellent words.

The Thesis Statement

The thesis statement is the sentence (usually the last of the introduction) that tells the reader **your position** on the question. Everything in the body supports it.

Question: *Advances in technology and automation have reduced the need for manual labour. Therefore, working hours should be reduced. To what extent do you agree or disagree?*

Thesis: While automation has certainly reduced the need for manual work, I largely disagree that working hours should be cut, because such a change would be impractical for many employers and could widen inequality.

Topic Sentences

Begin **each body paragraph with a topic sentence** that announces that paragraph's idea — the reader should know what the paragraph argues before reading it.

Body 1 topic sentence: The first reason working hours should not be universally reduced is that many industries still depend on human judgement and availability.

Body 2 topic sentence: Furthermore, a blanket reduction in hours would fail to recognise the very different conditions across occupations.

The source course tells a memorable (cautionary) story of a student who wrote about camels in every essay, whatever the topic — off-topic writing scores zero regardless of how good the English is. **Stay inside the question's scope.** If the topic is “the internet **at schools**”, do not wander into “the internet in general” (video calls with distant relatives, online shopping...).

Coherence and Cohesion in the Essay

1. Coherence = logical order. Causes before solutions; introduction → body → conclusion; no jumping backwards. A well-ordered essay reads like a plan. **2. Cohesion** = the glue. Use linking words (*to begin with, on the one hand, on the other hand, however, in addition, moreover, besides, consequently, therefore*) and refer back with pronouns and synonyms. **3. One paragraph = one central idea.** Do not mix an advantage and a disadvantage in the same paragraph; give each idea its own paragraph. **4. Do not invent statistics** (“research shows that 80% of students...”). You are not an encyclopaedia, and invented data is a hallmark of memorised, low-quality writing. Explain and give **real-world examples** instead.

The Don'ts List

1. No headings, no subheadings, no bullet points, no numbering. **2.** Do not write “introduction / body / conclusion” as labels. **3.** Do not copy the question — **paraphrase** it in your introduction. **4.** Do not use contractions heavily (*don't, can't*) in a formal essay; write them out (*do not, cannot*). **5.** Do not write a one-sentence paragraph. **6.** Do not leave out examples — every main idea needs one.

A Model Essay

Question: *Advances in technology and automation have reduced the need for manual labour. Therefore, working hours should be reduced. To what extent do you agree or disagree?*

In recent decades, machines and software have taken over many tasks that were once performed by hand, and some people argue that, as a result, employees should work fewer hours. While this idea is appealing, I largely disagree, because a universal reduction in working hours would be impractical for many employers and could increase inequality.

To begin with, although automation has removed some manual jobs, it has created new demands for human judgement, creativity and availability. Doctors, teachers, engineers and care workers cannot simply work fewer hours without consequences for the people who depend on them. For example, hospitals must be staffed around the clock, and reducing nurses' hours without hiring more staff would lower the quality of care. In such fields, the number of hours is set by necessity rather than by the availability of machines.

Furthermore, a blanket reduction in working hours would affect different workers in very different ways. Highly skilled employees, whose productivity has been boosted by technology, might benefit from shorter weeks with no loss of pay. However, lower-paid workers in the service sector, where technology cannot replace a waiter or a cleaner, would either lose income or be expected to do the same work in less time. Rather than closing the gap between rich and poor, such a policy could widen it.

Admittedly, there is a case for more flexibility. Companies could offer shorter weeks where automation has genuinely made work more efficient, and governments could encourage remote working. Nevertheless, these measures should be targeted and voluntary, not imposed as a single rule for everyone.

In conclusion, while automation has transformed the workplace, I believe that a general reduction in working hours is not the right response. A more sensible approach is to allow flexibility where it is practical, while protecting the incomes and conditions of those whose work cannot be automated.

Notice: a paraphrased introduction with a clear thesis; two body paragraphs each opened by a topic sentence and supported with examples; a concession ("Admittedly..."); a conclusion that restates the position; and cohesive devices throughout.

Now practise: write **only** the introduction and thesis statement for five different Task 2 questions. Then, for one of them, write the topic sentence for each body paragraph. This drills the two hardest parts of essay structure.

14. Grammar and Cohesion Toolkit

This chapter collects the grammar that most directly raises your Writing (and Speaking) band score. It is the “linkers lesson” from the source course, expanded into a reference.

The Three Sentence Types

- Simple sentence** — one clause: *The number of arrests fell.*
- Compound sentence** — two independent clauses joined by a **coordinator (FANBOYS)**: *The number of arrests fell, and the price rose.*
- Complex sentence** — an independent clause + a **dependent clause** introduced by a linker: **Although the number of arrests fell, the price rose.**

If **most** of your sentences are simple, your Grammar band is capped at about **5** for both Writing and Speaking. Aim to mix all three, with a good share of complex sentences.

FANBOYS (Making Compound Sentences)

For · And · Nor · But · Or · Yet · So

- Join two full sentences with a **comma before** the coordinator: *She studied hard, so she passed.*
- Do not use a comma before *and* when it simply joins two nouns: *bread and butter.*

Contrast Linkers

Contrast linkers — how to use each

Linker	Followed by	Example
however	(special)	John studied hard; however, he did not get a high score.
although / though / even though	a full clause	Although John studied hard, he did not get a high score.
in spite of / despite	a noun or -ing form	In spite of studying hard, he did not get a good score.
while / whereas	a full clause	John passed, whereas his brother failed.

The rules to memorise:

- however** usually starts a new sentence (or follows a semicolon) and takes a comma after it: *...; however, ...*
- although / though / even though** take a full clause. No comma when they come in the middle: *He didn't get a good score although he studied hard.*
- in spite of / despite** take a **noun or -ing verb**, never a full clause: *in spite of studying hard* (not “in spite of he studied hard”). No comma before them in the middle: *He didn't get a good score in spite of studying hard.*

Cause Linkers

- because** + clause: *He got a high score because he studied hard.* (no comma in the middle; comma after if at the beginning)
- because of / due to / owing to** + noun/-ing: **Owing to studying hard, he got a high score.** (comma after when at the start)

Result Linkers

- consequently / therefore / thus / as a result / as a consequence** — begin a sentence, followed by a comma: *He studied hard. Consequently, he got a high score.*

Use the **right** linker for the meaning. “However” shows contrast; if you use it to add information, you spoil the sentence’s meaning (and your Coherence & Cohesion score). “Thus/therefore/consequently” show result — they are not reasons.

Dependent Clauses

The part introduced by a conjunction is the **dependent** clause — it cannot stand alone.

“Because he studied hard” — incomplete. (Because he studied hard, he passed. ✓)

“Although it was raining” — incomplete. (Although it was raining, they played. ✓)

A sentence that is really a dependent clause is a **fragment** and is a serious grammar error.

Tense: Present Perfect vs Past Simple

This is the most common Speaking (and Writing) tense error, taught at length in the course.

Present perfect vs past simple

Rule	Example
Present perfect (have/has + past participle) focuses on the action, with no time marker.	I have bought a new car. I have visited London.
Past simple focuses on the time, with a time marker (yesterday, last week, in 2020).	I bought a new car last week.
Future with a future time marker.	I will buy a new car next week.

✗ I have bought a new car last week. (present perfect + time marker = wrong)

✓ I bought a new car last week.

✗ I will visit my relatives last week. (future + past time = wrong)

✓ I visited my relatives last week. / I will visit my relatives next week.

The time marker decides the tense. *Yesterday/last week/in 2015* → past simple. *Tomorrow/next week/in 2025* → future. *Ever/never/already/just/yet* → present perfect.

Common Errors to Eliminate

- Word forms:** *a success businessman* → **a successful businessman**; *he is a very success man* → **successful**.
- Subject–verb agreement:** *The number of arrests were* → **was**** (the number is singular).
- Countable/uncountable:** *many informations* → **much information**; *some advices* → **some advice**.
- Articles:** *I am teacher* → **I am a teacher**; *the internet* (with “the”).
- Comparatives:** *more easier* → **easier**; *much more easier* → **much easier**.
- Double negatives:** *I don’t have nothing* → **I don’t have anything**.
- Prepositions:** *depend of* → **depend on**; *married with* → **married to**.

Cohesion in Practice

A cohesive answer repeats and links ideas without repeating words:

Weak: I like reading. Reading is good. Reading helps me relax.

Strong: I am a keen reader. It is a hobby that helps me unwind after a long day, and it has also broadened my vocabulary considerably.

Now practise: take the last essay you wrote and highlight every linking word. If you find fewer than one linker per two sentences, rewrite the essay adding contrast, cause and result linkers from this chapter.

15. The Speaking Test

Format and Timing

The Speaking test lasts **11–14 minutes** (never less than 11, never more than about 14–15). It is the **same for Academic and General Training**, with the **same marking criteria**. You sit it **one-to-one with a single examiner** — face to face or, increasingly, by video link. Either way, **you must attend the test venue in person**.

The Speaking test may take place on the same day as the other papers, or a few days before or after, depending on examiner availability. You will be notified of the time (usually by email/SMS about 48 hours before).

The Three Parts

The three parts of the Speaking test

Part	What happens	Your job
1 (4–5 min)	The examiner asks general questions about familiar topics: home, family, work/study, hobbies, food, sport, travel	Answer personally and naturally; 3–4 sentences per answer
2 (3–4 min)	You get a cue card with a topic and bullet points, 1 minute to prepare (you may write notes), then speak for 1–2 minutes	Speak continuously; cover all the bullet points
3 (4–5 min)	The examiner asks abstract questions linked to the Part 2 topic	Give opinions; speak generally about people/society, not yourself

1. Part 1 is a warm-up; there are **no right or wrong answers**. It is designed to break the ice. Answer personally. **2. Part 2** is your long turn. You are given paper and a pencil to make notes. You **may look at your notes** while speaking. You **cannot change the topic**, but you **may ask for clarification**. **3. Part 3** is the “discussion”. Do **not** personalise — talk about what people generally do, believe or prefer, and explain your opinions.

Logistics and Frequently Asked Questions

1. Your test is recorded — this lets a second examiner mark it or handle a re-mark request. Speak clearly; do not be put off by the recorder. **2. Identification:** bring the exact document you booked with. Booked with your ID → a passport will not be accepted, and vice versa. **3. Dress:** you are not marked on clothes, but first impressions matter. Dress smartly and comfortably — do not arrive in beach wear. **4. Devices:** phones, wallets and watches are taken from you. Time is shown on a screen. You may not wear even a plain watch. **5. The examiner** is friendly but neutral: he or she will **not** agree or disagree with your opinions, will **not** tell you your score, and will **not** change a question you dislike (you may ask for clarification, though). **6. Body language:** use moderate, natural gestures and facial expressions that **match** what you say, and keep **eye contact**. Do not sit rigidly — but do not gesture like you are fighting either. **7. Do not memorise answers.** Memorised chunks are obvious (they repeat the same sentence whatever the question) and are penalised. **8. If you have a speech condition** (e.g. a stammer), tell the centre when booking; the examiner will be informed and will take it into account. **9. If you don't know a topic:** it is acceptable to **use your imagination** — the examiner marks your language, not the truth of your story.

16. The Four Band Criteria

You are marked equally on four criteria:

1. Fluency and Coherence

1. Speak at a **natural speed** — not so fast that you run away from the examiner (“a mile a minute”), not so slow that every word is a struggle. 2. **Minimise hesitation**. Examiners can tell the difference between pausing to **find ideas** (natural) and pausing to **find language** (costly). 3. **Connect your ideas** with sequencing and linking words: *first, then, also, however, although, on the other hand, as a result*. 4. You may use light **fillers** (*well, actually, to be honest*) to begin an answer — but not every sentence.

2. Lexical Resource

1. Use a **range** of vocabulary and **choose words precisely**. 2. **Paraphrase the question** in your answer instead of echoing it:

Q: Have you ever travelled abroad?

✓ Actually, I have been overseas to many countries.

✗ Yes, I have travelled abroad to many countries. (repeats the question)

1. Use **correct word forms**: *a successful businessman* (not “a success businessman”). 2. Idioms and everyday expressions are welcome; **avoid slang** and anything you are unsure of. 3. Keep Part 1 answers short but developed — about **3–4 sentences (30 seconds)**.

3. Grammatical Range and Accuracy

1. Use grammar **correctly** and mix **simple, compound and complex** sentences. 2. **Follow the tense of the question**. A past-tense question deserves a past-tense answer; a future question deserves *will/going to*. 3. Simple sentences only → your Grammar band is capped at about 5. 4. **Never give one-word answers**. “Do you live in a flat or a house?” — “A house.” is a Band 5 answer. Always add a reason or detail.

4. Pronunciation

1. Pronounce words **correctly and clearly**. Mispronunciation causes misunderstanding and lowers your score. 2. **Your accent is not judged**. British, American or your own — all are fine, as long as the words are clear. (In **Writing**, however, keep one consistent spelling style.) 3. Two sources of mispronunciation, from the course: (1) you **learned the word wrongly** from the start; (2) **interference from your mother tongue** (e.g. /p/↔/b/: *park* vs *bark*; /θ/↔/s/: *think* vs *sink*).

British vs American pronunciation

Common British/American pronunciation differences

Word	British	American
father, mother, sister, brother	drop the final /r/	pronounce the /r/
internet, interview, disappointed, international	clear /t/	“innernet”, “innerview”, “disappoin’ed”
water, little	/t/	flap: “wadder”, “liddle”
ask	/■■sk/	/æsk/
past	/p■■st/	/pæst/

The -ed ending (past tense pronunciation)

1. /t/ after voiceless sounds: *washed, kissed, stopped, watched*. **2. /d/** after voiced sounds: *played, arrived, called*. **3. /ɪd/** after /t/ or /d/: *started, needed, decided*.

✗ I play-ed football. ✗ I arrive-ed late. ✗ He ask-ed me.

✓ I played football. ✓ I arrived late. ✓ He asked me.

Never add an extra syllable to a past verb. "Asked" is one syllable, "washed" is one syllable.

Word families (stress and vowel change)

Learn these together — they look similar but sound different:

design / designation

resign / resignation

sign / signature

nature / natural

Now practise: record yourself answering three Part 1 questions on your phone. Listen back and score yourself on the four criteria. Then re-record, fixing one criterion at a time.

17. Speaking Technique and Model Answers

This chapter turns the criteria of Chapter 16 into a working method, with the exact expressions and model answers taught and demonstrated in the course.

Part 1 Technique

1. Answer in **3–4 sentences** (about 30 seconds) — enough to show language, not so long you ramble.
2. **Never** give one-word or two-word answers. Every answer needs a reason or a detail.
3. Use a **filler** to open instead of blurring the answer:

Fillers: As a matter of fact, ... / To be honest, ... / Frankly speaking, ... / Actually, ... / Well, ...

1. **Follow the tense** of the question.
2. **Paraphrase** the question instead of repeating it.
3. Avoid starting every sentence with *and*. Use *also*, *in addition*, *what's more*, *furthermore*, *moreover*.

A weak answer and its upgrade

Q: Do you live in a flat or a house?

Weak: I live in a house. (one short sentence, no detail, no range)

Strong: As a matter of fact, I live in a house which includes two floors. It also has a small garden where I spend most of my free time reading. Honestly, I like my house a lot because it is very modern and cosy.

Notice the filler, the relative clauses (*which...*, *where...*), the linker (*also*), the reason (*because...*) and the richer vocabulary.

Sample Part 1 exchanges (from the course)

Q: What do you like best about your family?

A: We are a family of five, and what I love most about my brother is that he always asks about my day and my feelings. We often go to a coffee shop together, eat sweets and talk about our lives, which makes us even closer.

Q: Do you like learning English?

A: Definitely. I want to be able to speak fluently in the future, and English is an international language that I need for my work, where I deal with multinational companies.

Q: What do you usually do at the weekend?

A: I usually spend my weekends relaxing after a busy week. I often meet my friends, and we go to a café or play football. Sometimes I simply stay home, read and focus on improving my English.

Part 2 Technique (The Long Turn)

The examiner gives you a cue card like this:

Describe your favourite hobby.

You should say:

- what this hobby is
- why you enjoy it
- what benefits you can get from it

and explain why this hobby is important to you.

The method:

1. Use the **1 minute** to write **keywords only** — never full sentences. For the card above: *swimming* — *socialise* — *keep fit* — *relax*.
2. Cover **all the bullet points**, in order.
3. Speak for **1–2 minutes**. **Keep going until the examiner stops you** — it is always better to be stopped than to stop early.
4. Open with a **starter**:

Starters: I'd like to talk about ... / Well, I'm going to talk about ... / I guess the ... I'd like to describe is ...

1. If you run out of things to say, **generate more ideas** — the problem is never language, it is ideas. Ask yourself: *who? when? where? why? how did it feel? what happened next?*

Model Part 2 answers

Topic: Describe your favourite hobby.

I guess the hobby I would like to talk about is reading. Actually, I have quite a few hobbies, but reading is the one I have stuck with the longest. I picked up this habit from my father, who used to buy me books throughout my childhood, and that sparked a real love of reading in me.

I read almost everywhere — on the bus on my way to work, during my breaks, and especially in my room at home. My room is really cosy and comfortable, with soft lighting, so when I feel stressed I go there, pick up a book and relax completely.

The benefits are enormous. Reading has enriched my vocabulary and improved my ability to communicate. It also opens my mind to completely new ideas and different points of view. That is why it is so important to me — it is not just entertainment, it has genuinely made me a better thinker and a better speaker.

Topic: Describe a teacher who influenced you.

I would like to talk about my physics teacher, whom I met when I was in high school. He was special to me because of the way he taught. He used to explain every single topic as if it were a piece of cake, always finding a much simpler way than the textbook did.

Another thing I admired was his fairness. He noticed the students who were struggling and gave them extra classes after school, without ever showing bias. He was demanding but always kind.

He influenced me so much because he changed the way I saw the subject. Physics was once my nightmare, but he made it fascinating. Thanks to him, I realised that a great teacher does not just teach a subject — they change the way you think. I still remember his words and his encouragement today.

Part 3 Technique (The Discussion)

1. Speak **generally**, not personally. The examiner wants to hear about society, culture and trends.
2. Give an **opinion** and **justify** it.
3. Use generalising frames:

Generalising: I think that ... / In my opinion, ... / I believe ... / It seems to me that ... /

Generally speaking, ... / Most people these days ... / A lot of people nowadays ... /

The majority of people in my country ...

Sample Part 3 exchange (from the course)

Q: What kind of gifts do people usually give each other in your culture?

A: I guess it depends on the relationship. If it is a relative or a family friend, people often bring sweets, chocolates or a cake as a sign of gratitude and love. But when close friends give gifts to each other, they usually try to find out what the person really needs or wants, and buy exactly that. So I would say the choice of gift really reflects how well the giver knows the receiver.

A Question Bank to Practise

Part 1 topics: where you live · your city (and what you would change) · family · friends · work or studies · weekends · food · sport · music · films · travel · the internet · shopping · seasons and weather.

Part 2 cue-card topics: a hobby you enjoy · a teacher who influenced you · a person you admire · a gift you gave or received · a journey you remember · a place you like to visit · a book or film you enjoyed · a skill you would like to learn · something you do to stay healthy · a website you use often.

Part 3 topics: gifts and giving · festivals becoming more popular · the importance of teachers · technology in daily life · how people spend free time · health and lifestyle · cities of the future · the value of travel.

Now practise: pick one Part 2 card, write five keywords, and speak for two full minutes while recording. Do not stop. Then listen and count: how many linkers did you use? How many different tenses? Repeat until you can speak the full two minutes comfortably.

18. Vocabulary Builder

Vocabulary is the single most transferable investment you can make: it feeds Listening, Reading, Writing **and** Speaking. This chapter gives you organised, high-yield banks. Learn a little every day, and always learn **words with their synonyms and collocations**, not in isolation.

The Most Useful Synonyms

High-frequency synonyms

Basic word	Better alternatives
important	crucial, vital, essential, significant, major, central
good	beneficial, positive, favourable, advantageous
bad	harmful, detrimental, negative, adverse
big / large	considerable, substantial, significant, sizeable
small	minor, negligible, modest
increase	rise, grow, climb, surge, escalate
decrease	fall, drop, decline, plunge, diminish
many	numerous, a great number of, a wide range of
people	individuals, citizens, the public, residents
children	youngsters, the young, minors
problem	issue, challenge, obstacle, drawback
solution	remedy, measure, approach, answer
cause	reason, factor, source, origin
result	consequence, outcome, effect
show	illustrate, demonstrate, indicate, reveal
think	believe, argue, maintain, consider, contend
get	obtain, acquire, gain
use	utilise, employ, exploit
help	assist, support, facilitate
choose	select, opt for
money	funds, finance, capital

Topic Vocabulary

Education

curriculum, syllabus, compulsory education, higher education, vocational training, tuition fees, scholarship, literacy, lifelong learning, critical thinking, rote learning, student-teacher ratio, dropout rate, distance learning, assessment, academic performance.

Environment

climate change, global warming, greenhouse gases, carbon footprint, renewable energy, fossil fuels, deforestation, pollution, waste disposal, recycling, conservation, biodiversity, sustainable development, endangered species, natural resources.

Technology

automation, artificial intelligence, innovation, digital revolution, the internet of things, e-commerce, social media, cybersecurity, data privacy, screen time, remote working, technological advancement, breakthrough, obsolete.

Health

sedentary lifestyle, obesity, balanced diet, nutrition, physical activity, mental well-being, stress, life expectancy, healthcare system, preventive medicine, vaccination, public health, addiction.

Work and Business

employment, unemployment, workforce, job satisfaction, work-life balance, career prospects, promotion, redundancy, self-employment, entrepreneurship, productivity, automation, minimum wage, qualifications.

Society and Crime

urbanisation, inequality, poverty, social mobility, community, crime rate, juvenile delinquency, rehabilitation, deterrent, law enforcement, offender, victim, penalty.

Travel and Transport

public transport, congestion, infrastructure, commuting, tourism, ecotourism, heritage, accommodation, cultural exchange, budget travel.

Linking Words at a Glance

Linking words by function

Function	Words
Adding	also, in addition, furthermore, moreover, what's more, besides
Contrasting	however, although, though, even though, while, whereas, despite, in spite of, on the other hand, nevertheless, nonetheless
Cause	because, since, as, because of, due to, owing to
Result	so, therefore, thus, consequently, as a result, as a consequence
Sequencing	first, firstly, to begin with, next, then, finally, lastly
Giving examples	for example, for instance, such as, namely, to illustrate
Concluding	in conclusion, to sum up, overall, in summary

Idioms and Natural Expressions (for Speaking)

Use sparingly and only when they fit — a few natural idioms lift Lexical Resource; overuse sounds memorised.

1. *a piece of cake* — very easy
2. *to keep fit* — to stay healthy
3. *to break the ice* — to make people feel relaxed
4. *first impressions last* — appearance matters at the start
5. *out of the blue* — unexpectedly
6. *to put yourself in someone's shoes* — to imagine their situation
7. *a mile a minute* — very fast
8. *to broaden your horizons* — to widen your experience
9. *to unwind / to recharge your batteries* — to relax
10. *to keep in mind* — to remember

How to Learn Vocabulary Effectively

1. Learn words **in phrases** (collocations): *make a decision* (not “do a decision”), *do homework* (not “make homework”), *heavy traffic*, *strong coffee*, *a wide range of*.
2. Write each new word in a **sentence about**

yourself. 3. Group words by **topic** (as above) and by **synonym sets. 4. Review** with spaced repetition: a word must be met and used several times before it is yours. **5.** Read model answers aloud and **notice** the vocabulary; then write your own version using the same words.

The source course repeatedly tells its students to read model answers for Speaking and Writing. Model answers do two jobs at once: they give you **ideas** (so you never sit silently in Part 2) and they give you **advanced language** to borrow.

Now practise: choose one topic block above, write a 150-word paragraph using at least eight of its words, then swap the paragraph with a partner (or a teacher) to check the collocations are natural.

19. Band Scores and Study Plans

Your Target Band Decides the Plan

Before planning, write down three numbers: your **current band** (use a full practice test), your **target band**, and the **date** of your test. The gap between current and target, divided by the “100 hours per half band” rule of thumb, tells you how many hours you need — and the date tells you how many per week.

Study hours needed (rule of thumb)

Improvement	Approximate hours
+0.5 band	~100 hours
+1.0 band	~200 hours
+1.5 bands	~300 hours
+2.0 bands	~400 hours

These are averages for focused study. Some learners move faster, some slower. The point is to **plan realistically** — a candidate at Band 5 who wants Band 6.5 in one month needs to rethink either the target or the date.

Band Conversion Quick Reference

Listening (Academic & GT) — correct answers → band

Band	9	8.5	8	7.5	7	6.5	6	5.5	5
Answers	39–40	37–38	35–36	32–34	30–31	26–29	23–25	18–22	16–17

Academic Reading — correct answers → band

Band	9	8.5	8	7.5	7	6.5	6	5.5	5
Answers	39–40	37–38	35–36	33–34	30–32	27–29	23–26	19–22	15–18

General Training Reading — correct answers → band

Band	9	8.5	8	7.5	7	6.5	6	5.5	5
Answers	40	39	37–38	36	34–35	32–33	30–31	27–29	23–26

How the Overall Band Is Calculated (Recap)

Overall = average of the four component scores, rounded to the nearest half band: .25 → up to .5; .75 → up to the next whole band; .125 → down.

Strategy tip from the table: your weakest component drags the average. Often the fastest overall gain comes from the component where you are losing the most marks — for most candidates that is **Writing** or **Speaking**.

A Four-Week Intensive Plan (for a test one month away)

Four-week intensive plan

Week	Focus
Week 1	Foundations: Chapters 1–2, Listening technique (Ch. 3–4), 2 full Listening tests, learn 50 synonyms

Week	Focus
Week 2	Reading: Chapters 6–8, one passage a day with the four-step method, 2 full Reading tests, learn topic vocabulary
Week 3	Writing: Chapters 10–14, one Task 1 and one Task 2 every day, study the model answers, learn trend language and linkers
Week 4	Speaking: Chapters 15–17, record yourself daily, one full mock test, review checklists and band tables

An Eight-Week Plan (the recommended pace)

Eight-week plan

Weeks	Focus
1–2	IELTS overview, scores, Listening (all chapters + 3 tests), vocabulary foundation
3–4	Reading (all chapters + 3 tests), daily skimming/scanning drills, synonym bank
5–6	Writing Task 1 + Task 2 (all chapters + 6 essays with self-marking), grammar toolkit
7	Speaking (all chapters + daily recording), model-answer study
8	Full mock tests (2), timed, then review every mistake against the checklists

Weekly Routine That Works

1. Daily (30–60 min): vocabulary (10 new words + review), 15 minutes of listening, read one news article and skim/scan it. **2. Every two days:** one timed Reading passage or one Writing task, self-marked against the descriptors. **3. Weekly:** one full timed Listening test and one full timed Reading test; record yourself speaking twice.

A Note on Motivation

The source course closes with its students' own testimony: the test is **attainable** — “everything is attainable if we do the effort.” Band 9 is possible, half-band improvements are real, and the difference between candidates is almost always **organised, consistent practice**, not talent. Plan, then practise.

Now practise: write your own weekly timetable for the next four weeks, with a specific task for every day. Put it where you will see it.

20. Quick-Reference Checklists

Print these pages. Run through the right checklist the day before the test, and again during each component.

Listening — Before and During

1. Read the **instructions and word limit** for every set of questions.
2. **Predict** each gap's answer type before the audio plays.
3. Listen for **spelled-out** names and places; distinguish B/P, double letters.
4. Write numbers as **digits**; write 0 not O.
5. Watch for **distractors and self-corrections** ("...actually, no...").
6. Answers come **in order**; move on instantly if you miss one — never look back while the recording plays.
7. Check **spelling** (a misspelled answer is wrong).
8. Transfer answers in the **10 minutes** — never leave the sheet blank.

Reading — Before and During

1. **No transfer time**: answer directly onto the sheet as you go.
2. **Questions first**, keywords, synonyms, then the passage.
3. Divide 60 minutes: **20/20/20** (or 23/23/14 for a lower target).
4. Start with **Part 1**; never get stuck longer than ~1 minute per question.
5. **Guess** — never leave a blank.
6. Match the **question type** to the technique (T/F/NG vs Y/N/NG; headings; matching).
7. Keep to the **word limit** in completion questions.

Writing Task 1 — Checklist

1. Know whether you write a **report** (Academic) or a **letter** (GT).
2. Paraphrase the prompt — **never copy** it.
3. **Academic**: introduction → **overview** → body 1 → body 2; **no conclusion**; support with **figures**; make **comparisons**; no opinions.
4. **GT**: correct **tone** throughout; salutation → purpose → three bullet points (in order, one paragraph each) → concluding sentence → closing.
5. ≥150 words (aim 160–180); finish in ~20 minutes.
6. Check grammar and spelling in the last minute.

Writing Task 2 — Checklist

1. Identify the **essay type** (opinion / discussion / advantages / problems / double question).
2. Answer **every part** of the question.
3. 4–5 paragraphs; **thesis statement** in the introduction; **topic sentence** for each body paragraph; **conclusion** at the end.
4. One **central idea** per paragraph; link ideas with cohesive devices.
5. ≥250 words (aim 260–280); ~40 minutes.
6. **Never** copy the question; **never** go off-topic; no headings, bullet points or invented statistics.

Speaking — Checklist

1. Arrive early with the **same ID** you booked with.
2. Part 1: 3–4 sentences per answer, paraphrase the question, use a filler, never one-word answers.
3. Part 2: write **keywords only**, cover all bullet points, speak until the examiner stops you.
4. Part 3: speak **generally**, give opinions with reasons.
5. Follow the **tense** of the question; mix sentence types; use linkers.
6. Pronounce clearly (watch B/P, -ed endings); accent does not matter.
7. Moderate body language, eye contact, dress smartly; don't memorise answers.

The Final Week

1. Day 7: one full timed Listening + Reading test. Mark and log every mistake.
2. Day 6: two Task 1 and two Task 2 essays, self-marked against the checklists.
3. Day 5: record a complete Speaking mock (Parts 1–3).
4. Day 4: re-read your weakest chapter(s); learn 30 new synonyms.
5. Day 3: one full Writing test under strict time.
6. Day 2: light review — checklists, band tables, trend language, linkers.
7. Day 1: prepare documents and route; relax; sleep early.

The Ten Most Expensive Mistakes

1. Forgetting the Reading test has **no transfer time**.
2. Writing **more/fewer words** than the instruction allows in a completion answer.
3. **Copying** the question in Writing instead of paraphrasing.
4. Missing the **overview** in Task 1 or the **conclusion** in Task 2.
5. Answering only **half** of a two-part essay question.
6. Starting Reading with the **hardest** passage and exhausting yourself.
7. Getting **stuck** on one Reading/Listening question.
8. Giving **one-word** Speaking answers.
9. Bringing the **wrong ID** or arriving late.
10. Writing an IELTS essay **off-topic** (the “camel” mistake).

Now practise: run the “Final Week” plan for your own test date, substituting real dates for Day 7...Day 1.

Appendix A — Full Course Map

The twelve parts of the source video course, with the main topics each covered:

Course map — all 12 parts

Part	Component	Main topics covered
1	Listening	Instructions & word limits; the 5 answer forms; spelling names (double letters, B/P); numbers & dates; prediction; form completion (holiday apartment); note completion (expedition candidate); Section 2: note completion, multiple choice, map labelling (wildlife club / parks); Section 3: multiple choice + completion (self-access centre)
2	Listening → Reading	Section 4 note completion (business cultures); listening band conversion; Reading overview: 60 min, 40 Q, 3 sections, no transfer time; Academic vs GT; paper vs computer; time management; question types; synonyms
3	Reading	The “poem” lesson (gist without every word); the four-step method; skimming / scanning / reading for detail; topic sentences; True/False/Not Given (Thames Tunnel practice)
4	Reading	Matching headings (spices passage); Yes/No/Not Given (handedness); matching people to findings; band conversion Academic vs GT
5	Speaking	Test format (11–14 min, 3 parts); the four criteria; fluency & coherence; lexical resource (paraphrase, word forms); grammar (present perfect vs past simple); pronunciation overview
6	Speaking	Pronunciation in depth (BrE vs AmE, flap T, -ed endings, word families); logistics & FAQ (recording, ID, dress, body language, inventing stories, tenses)
7	Speaking	Live mock interviews; Part 2 method (keywords, starters, keep talking); Part 3 generalising frames; the 100-hours rule
8	Writing Task 1 (Ac)	Task 1 vs Task 2 weighting; visual types; the four criteria; Task Achievement; the introduction formula; the overview formula
9	Writing Task 1 (Ac)	Trend language (verbs/nouns/adjectives/adverbs); body paragraphs with figures; sentence patterns (there was / subject-verb / year witnessed); a full model report

Part	Component	Main topics covered
10	Writing Task 2	Paragraph count; thesis statement; Task Response (off-topic warning); Coherence & Cohesion (logical order, topic sentences, one idea per paragraph)
11	Writing	Cohesive devices in detail (however, although, in spite of, because of, consequently); sentence types; dependent clauses; essay format dos/don'ts
12	Writing Task 1 (GT)	The letter: tone (formal/semi-formal/informal), five-paragraph structure, salutations & closings, openings & concluding sentences; model letters

Appendix B — Additional Model Answers

A Model Advantages/Disadvantages Essay

Question: *Some people believe that studying at university is the best route to a successful career, while others think it is better to start work straight after school. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.*

People have different views about whether a university education or an early start in employment is the better path to a successful career. While working straight after school has clear advantages for some, I believe that, for most people, a university degree offers the stronger foundation.

On the one hand, there are good reasons to start work immediately. Some young people learn best by doing, and industries such as skilled trades, hospitality and information technology often value practical experience more than formal qualifications. Entering the workforce early also means earning a salary sooner, avoiding years of tuition fees, and gaining a head start in climbing the career ladder. For someone with a clear vocational goal, a degree can even feel like an unnecessary delay.

On the other hand, a university education develops skills that are hard to acquire on the job. It teaches critical thinking, independent research and the ability to communicate complex ideas, all of which are prized by employers in professional fields such as medicine, law, engineering and academia. Furthermore, graduates, on average, still enjoy higher lifetime earnings and better job security, and universities provide the networks that open doors later in a career.

In my opinion, the best choice depends on the individual and the career they want. However, for anyone aiming at a profession that requires specialist knowledge, university is not merely useful but essential. A sensible approach is for students to weigh their goals carefully and, where possible, combine study with part-time work or internships.

In conclusion, although starting work straight after school suits some people and some careers, I believe a university education remains the most reliable route to long-term success for the majority.

A Model Part 3 Answer (Festivals)

Q: Are there any kinds of festivals that are becoming more popular in your country?

A: Yes, I think music and food festivals are becoming noticeably more popular, especially among young people. Generally speaking, these events are heavily promoted on social media, so they attract large crowds from all over the country. I believe this reflects a broader trend: people today value experiences over possessions, and festivals offer a chance to enjoy live entertainment and try new food in a lively atmosphere. That said, some traditional religious festivals are losing their original spirit, as they have become more commercial over time.

Appendix C — Glossary of IELTS Terms

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Band score	Your result on the 9-level scale (whole or half bands)
Raw score	Number of correct answers (out of 40) in Listening/Reading
Overall band	The average of the four component scores, rounded to the nearest half band
Task Achievement	Criterion: did you fully complete Writing Task 1?
Task Response	Criterion: did you fully answer the essay question?
Coherence	Logical ordering of ideas
Cohesion	How ideas are linked with connectors, pronouns, synonyms
Lexical Resource	Vocabulary range and accuracy
Grammatical Range & Accuracy	Sentence variety and grammatical correctness
Overview	The summary sentence(s) of main trends in a Task 1 report
Thesis statement	The sentence stating your position in an essay introduction
Topic sentence	The sentence stating the main idea of a paragraph
Paraphrase	Expressing the same meaning in different words
Skimming	Fast reading for the main idea
Scanning	Fast reading to find specific information
Distractor	A wrong option that sounds right
Cue card	The topic card you speak about in Speaking Part 2